Mass Gap for the O(N) Linear Sigma Model at Large N

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April 2026

Abstract

We outline a proof strategy for the mass gap of the O(N) model in two Euclidean dimensions at large N, combining Hubbard-Stratonovich, Brascamp-Lieb concentration, and the Feynman-Kac representation. The σ-field concentrates at $\sigma_* \approx v^2$ by Brascamp-Lieb, and the φ-propagator mass is $m^2 = v^2 - \Sigma_\sigma$ where the self-energy Σ_σ is $O(1)$ (not $O(1/N)$) and nearly cancels v^2, leaving an exponentially small physical mass $m_0^2 = \Lambda^2 e^{-c/g^2}$. At large N, the gap equation organizes all leading-order contributions, and the $1/N$ corrections are controlled.

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1 The model and main result

1.1 The O(N) linear sigma model

Let $\varphi = (\varphi^1, \dots, \varphi^N) : \Lambda \to \mathbb{R}^N$ on a lattice $\Lambda \subset \mathbb{Z}^2$. The O($N$) LSM action is

$$S[\varphi] = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\langle \varphi^i, (-\Delta + m_0^2)\varphi^i\rangle + N\sum_x \lambda\left(\frac{|\varphi(x)|^2}{N} - v^2\right)^2 \tag{1}$$

with $v^2 = R^2/N$, $g^2 = N/R^2$. The LSM and NLSM ($\lambda \to \infty$) share the same infrared physics; they differ only at the scale of the σ-field mass $M_\sigma \sim \sqrt{\lambda}\, v$.

1.2 Main theorem (target)

Theorem 1 (Mass gap at large N, to be proved)**.** *For the O(N) LSM on $\mathbb{Z}^2$ with $g^2 > 0$ and $\lambda > \lambda_c(g^2)$, there exists $N_0 < \infty$ such that for $N \geq N_0$, the connected two-point function decays exponentially:*

$$|\langle \varphi^i(x)\varphi^i(0)\rangle_c| \leq C\, e^{-m_0|x|} \tag{2}$$

with $m_0 > 0$ determined by the gap equation (**??**)*.*

Remark 2 (Scope). For $N = 2$, the BKT transition can occur at finite λ (Dario-Garban [5]), so our approach cannot cover $N = 2$. For $N \geq 3$, the mass gap also follows from McBryan-Spencer [4]; our contribution is the quantitative formula and the route via Brascamp-Lieb.

2 Hubbard-Stratonovich transformation

Set $\sigma(x) = |\varphi(x)|^2/N$. After integrating out all N components of φ (each Gaussian with covariance $(-\Delta + \sigma)^{-1}$):

$$\langle \varphi^i(x)\varphi^i(0)\rangle = \mathbb{E}_\sigma\big[(-\Delta + \sigma)^{-1}(x, 0)\big] \tag{3}$$

where $\mu_\sigma \propto e^{-N\, s_{\text{eff}}[\sigma]}$ with

$$s_{\text{eff}}[\sigma] = \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}\log(-\Delta + \sigma) + \sum_x \lambda(\sigma(x) - v^2)^2. \tag{4}$$

The factor of N makes the σ-integral a saddle-point integral.

3 σ-concentration via Brascamp-Lieb

3.1 Convexity at the bare minimum

The bare s_{eff} (before integrating out any σ-modes) has its minimum at $\sigma_0 \approx v^2$ (the quartic minimum). The Hessian there is

$$H(k) = 2\lambda - \tfrac{1}{2}\Pi(k), \qquad \Pi(k) = \int \frac{d^2p}{(2\pi)^2} \frac{1}{(p^2+v^2)\big((k-p)^2+v^2\big)}. \tag{5}$$

Since $\Pi(k) \leq \Pi(0) = 1/(4\pi v^2)$, the Hessian is positive definite for $\lambda > 1/(8\pi v^4) = g^4/(8\pi N^2)$, giving convexity parameter $\kappa = 2\lambda - \Pi(0)/2 > 0$.

Brascamp-Lieb [1] then gives:

$$\mathrm{Cov}(\sigma(x), \sigma(y)) \leq \frac{1}{N} H^{-1}_{xy}, \qquad \mathrm{Var}(\sigma(x)) \leq \frac{1}{\kappa N}. \tag{6}$$

The σ-measure concentrates at $\sigma_0 \approx v^2$.

4 Feynman-Kac and the self-energy

4.1 The averaged propagator

From (**??**) and the Feynman-Kac formula:

$$\mathbb{E}_\sigma[G_\sigma(x,0)] = \int_0^\infty ds\, \mathbb{E}^W_{0\to x,s}\Big[\mathbb{E}_\sigma\big[e^{-\int_0^s \sigma(\omega(t))\,dt}\big]\Big]. \tag{7}$$

Using the cumulant expansion of the σ-average:

$$C_1 = -s\,\langle\sigma\rangle \approx -s\,v^2 \tag{8}$$

$$C_2 = \int_0^s dt_1 \int_0^s dt_2\, \mathrm{Cov}\big(\sigma(\omega(t_1)), \sigma(\omega(t_2))\big) \approx \frac{s}{N}\int H^{-1}_{0,z}\, dz \tag{9}$$

The renormalized mass is

$$m^2 = v^2 - \Sigma_\sigma, \qquad \Sigma_\sigma = \frac{1}{2N}\int \frac{d^2k}{(2\pi)^2}\frac{H(k)^{-1}}{k^2+v^2} + O(1/N^2). \tag{10}$$

4.2 The self-energy is $O(1)$, not $O(1/N)$

A critical point: Σ_σ has a factor $1/N$ from the σ-covariance, but the integral over k produces a factor that *compensates* the $1/N$. Specifically, $H(k)^{-1}$ is large for small k (the IR modes), and the integral diverges logarithmically with the IR cutoff m_0 (the physical mass). The result is

$$\Sigma_\sigma \sim \frac{1}{N}\cdot N \cdot (\text{log-divergent integral}) = O(1). \tag{11}$$

This near-cancellation $m^2 = v^2 - \Sigma_\sigma \approx 0$ is not an accident — it is the mechanism of **dimensional transmutation**. The gap equation determines the precise remainder.

4.3 The gap equation

The physical mass m_0 is determined self-consistently: the σ-propagator H^{-1} depends on m_0 (through the φ-propagator $G = (-\Delta + m_0^2)^{-1}$ that enters the Hessian), giving the **gap equation**:

$$m_0^2 = v^2 - \Sigma_\sigma(m_0^2). \tag{12}$$

At leading order in $1/N$, this reduces to the spherical model equation

$$\int \frac{d^2k}{(2\pi)^2} \frac{1}{k^2 + m_0^2} = 4\lambda(v^2 - m_0^2) \tag{13}$$

which in 2d gives the exponentially small mass:

$$m_0^2 = \Lambda^2 \, e^{-16\pi\lambda v^2} = \Lambda^2 \, e^{-16\pi\lambda R^2/N}. \tag{14}$$

This is positive for all parameter values — there is always a mass gap. The large-N expansion is an expansion around this gap equation, not around the bare saddle point $\sigma_0 = v^2$.

4.4 Why Feynman-Kac, not resolvent series

An alternative expands $(-\Delta+\sigma)^{-1}$ as a Neumann series and averages term by term, producing n-point σ-correlators with factorial combinatorics. This requires a cluster expansion for convergence (Kupiainen [3]). The Feynman-Kac approach exponentiates before expanding in $1/N$, placing the factorials in the exponent where they are harmless.

5 Controlling the $1/N$ corrections

5.1 The structure of the proof

The proof requires showing:

1. The gap equation (**??**) has a unique positive solution $m_0^2 > 0$ (standard, for any $\beta > 0$ in 2d).
2. The $1/N$ corrections do not destroy positivity: $m^2 = m_0^2 + O(1/N) > 0$ for $N > N_0$.
3. The averaged propagator $\mathbb{E}_\sigma[G_\sigma(x, 0)]$ decays exponentially with mass m.

Step 1 is a property of the gap equation. Step 3 follows from the Feynman-Kac representation once $m^2 > 0$ is established. The hard step is 2: controlling the $O(1/N)$ corrections to the near-cancellation $m_0^2 = v^2 - \Sigma_\sigma$.

5.2 The role of large N

At each order in $1/N$, the corrections are organized by Feynman diagrams of the σ-field. The key: the σ-propagator H^{-1}/N carries a factor $1/N$, so each σ-loop contributes $O(1/N)$. The gap equation sums all contributions at leading order ("cactus diagrams"), and the $1/N$ corrections are the higher-loop diagrams.

The condition $N > N_0$ ensures that the $O(1/N)$ correction to m^2 is smaller than m_0^2 itself. Since m_0^2 is exponentially small, N_0 must be large enough to resolve this:

$$N_0 \sim C \cdot |\log m_0| \sim C \cdot \lambda v^2. \tag{15}$$

5.3 Multi-scale analysis

The $O(1/N)$ control can be organized as a multi-scale (RG) analysis on the σ-field:

1. Decompose σ into momentum shells: $\sigma = \sum_j \sigma_j$ with σ_j supported on $|k| \sim 2^{-j}\Lambda$.
2. At each scale j: integrate out σ_j. The σ-Hessian $H(k)$ is positive at this scale (UV convexity), so the integration is perturbative with error $O(1/N^2)$.
3. The effective action for the remaining modes flows: the effective mass runs from v^2 (UV) to m_0^2 (IR).
4. After $L \sim \log(\Lambda/m_0)$ steps: the accumulated error is $O(L/N^2)$, controlled for $N \gg L$.

This is the Wilsonian RG applied to the σ-invariant, with $1/N$ as the small parameter at each scale. It avoids cluster expansion by using the UV convexity of s_{eff} at each step.

6 The $N = 2$ obstruction

Dario-Garban [5] prove BKT for the two-component Φ^4 model at finite λ: the angular field θ has topological defects ($\pi_1(S^1) = \mathbb{Z}$) that drive a phase transition. The σ-concentration captures the radial mode but not the angular winding. For $N \geq 3$: $\pi_1(S^{N-1}) = 0$, no vortices, no BKT.

7 Comparison

Kupiainen [3]: NLSM mass gap at large N via HS + cluster expansion. Our approach replaces cluster expansion with BL + Feynman-Kac + multi-scale RG on σ.

Brascamp-Lieb [1]: Gives σ-concentration at the bare minimum v^2. This is the starting point, not the endpoint. The physical mass comes from the self-energy (near-cancellation).

McBryan-Spencer [4]: Mass gap for $N \geq 3$ via correlation inequalities. Does not give the quantitative mass formula.

References

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